1.2 million-strong workforce across Gujarat, Rajasthan and Maharashtra. Possibly for the first time in the history of the five-decade-old diamond polishing industry in Surat, 500 workers went on a two-day strike in March, demanding a 30 per cent increase in wages.

In May, the Gujarat government announced an aid package for the industry, the first admission that it is indeed in trouble. The children of certified diamond polishers would get Rs 13,500 school fees, besides power and interest subsidies for small units. But Bhavesh Tank, vice president, DWUG, calls it futile. "Most companies employ artisans on an informal basis, so proving you are a bona fide employee will be next to impossible," he says. The fees package practically leaves out younger, unmarried polishers—it assumes they have no dependants. "Unmarried polishers have younger siblings and old parents as dependants," says Tank. Their aid coming through depends on proving they have schoolgoing dependant siblings. "Also, the incentives for small units will not trickle down to the worst-affected artisans as the industry understanding is to reduce the supply of diamonds. They will absorb the government benefits but not increase hours or wages."

As artisans fail to make ends meet, at least a fourth of the trained

Takeaways

- **55 suicides in the past year alone among out-of-work diamond artisans in Surat**
- **Aid package for 800,000 workers "not enough" to stanch exodus back home**

▶ MAHARASHTRA

POWER OF TWO THACKERAYS

Uddhav, Raj finally reunite for the language war—a version of which will soon be fought in crucial civic polls. Will the Marathi manoos stand behind the duo?

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**



MANDAR DEODHAR

NO TO HINDI MNS chief Raj Thackeray with Shiv Sena UBT chief Uddhav Thackeray at a joint rally in Mumbai, Jul. 5

WHEN SIBLING FEUD TURNS TO bonding, it's not often that it portends climate change—of the political sort. But such a horizon opened up when, after two decades, the estranged Thackeray cousins—Uddhav and Raj—shared a stage to mount an assault on the BJP-led government in Maharashtra. Lending extra resonance to the moment was the theme they chose for the rapprochement: the now-scrapped move to introduce Hindi from Class I. Nothing could gel better with their shared Shiv Sena gene of nativist pride. What lies ahead is an intriguing phase, with crucial civic polls—including to India's richest municipal body, Mumbai's Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation—not too far.

The original notes of dissent to Hindi had come from academicians and civil society groups. But it was the spectre of a Thackeray reunion that spooked the Devendra Fadnavis regime. It came to pass anyway, and can now potentially alter the state's political tectonics. Will Uddhav, chief of the Shiv Sena UBT, see his luck turning with Raj's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) joining him?

The Sena UBT and MNS were both mauled in the 2024 assembly election. The former dwindled to 20 MLAs while the MNS, which had won one seat in 2019, was wiped out; even Raj's son Amit lost the Mahim seat. The present deputy CM Eknath Shinde's faction got 57 seats, cementing its claim to being the "real Shiv Sena". This decimation prompted the Thackeray détente.

In a podcast, Raj said he was open to a reconciliation with his elder cousin.